

10 SWAPS, AND HOW TO TELL WHEN SORRY IS WORTH IT

What to Say When Sorry Costs You

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1 When you're late, thank them for waiting

Thank them for the time they spent waiting, then ask where they are.

EXAMPLE

Don't say: "Sorry, my last meeting ran over."

Instead say: "Thanks for starting without me. What did I miss?"

Don't say: "Sorry, I know I'm always late to this one."

Instead say: "Thanks for waiting. I moved my 1:00 so it won't happen again."

If you're late to the same meeting every week, fix your calendar first.

2 When your work slips, thank them and give the date

Thank them for their patience, then give the new date and what's already done.

EXAMPLE

Don't say: "Sorry, still working on it!"

Instead say: "Still on it. The pricing section is done, and the rest lands Thursday."

Don't say: "So sorry, this is taking way longer than I thought."

Instead say: "This is bigger than I scoped. I need two more days, and here's why."

Every delay message gets a date. If you don't have one yet, give the date you'll have one.

3 When you have a question, ask it straight

Ask it with nothing in front of it. Calling it dumb tells people to ignore it before they hear it.

EXAMPLE

Don't say: "Sorry if I missed this somewhere."

Instead say: "Quick check: is the launch still the 14th?"

Don't say: "Sorry to bother you, do you have a sec?"

Instead say: "Do you have 10 minutes today? I need your call on the pricing page."

Read your message back and delete everything before the question.

4 When you follow up, say what you need and when

Say what you're waiting on and the day you need it, and tell them when it's the last one.

EXAMPLE

Don't say: "Sorry to bug you again, just checking in."

Instead say: "Still need the API estimate to lock the plan. Can you send it by Friday?"

Don't say: "Sorry for all the messages today."

Instead say: "Three things below. Only the first one needs you today."

Every follow-up names the thing you need and the day you need it.

5 When someone catches your mistake, credit the catch

Thank them for spotting it and say what you're doing about it. You still own the mistake.

EXAMPLE

Don't say: "Ugh, sorry, my bad, I should have caught that."

Instead say: "Good catch. Fixed, and I added a check so it won't happen again."

Don't say: "Sorry, I'm terrible with numbers."

Instead say: "Thanks for flagging. The corrected numbers are in the doc now."

Thank, fix, move on. Save sorry for step 6.

6 When your mistake cost someone, say sorry and mean it

This is when sorry is worth what it costs you. Say it once, in four parts: what happened, that it's on you, the fix, and what changes.

EXAMPLE

Don't say: "Sorry, sorry, ugh, I'm the worst."

Instead say: "I'm sorry. I sent the exec review the wrong revenue numbers this morning, and that's on me. The corrected deck is attached, and from now on a second person checks every number before it goes to leadership."

Say it once, then go fix the thing.

Check every message before you send it

Run this on anything you're about to send:

- ☐ Does it open with sorry? If you don't owe one, cut it.
- ☐ If something slipped, is the new date in it?
- ☐ If you're asking for something, does it say what and by when?
- ☐ Did you thank them for something they actually did?
- ☐ Did your mistake cost someone something? Then one full apology, using step 6.